The Oliver Family
1 Example Street
Bristol
BS1 4ST

Lyme Regis, Dorset

Dear Oliver,

Thank you for your letter! You found a stone shaped like a curly shell on the beach at Charmouth? Then I am almost certain it is an ammonite. Charmouth is just along the shore from my house, and I find ammonites there too. That shell belonged to a sea creature that lived millions of years ago.

You asked if I have ever found a real dinosaur. Here is the truth: not quite! I find creatures that lived at the same time as the dinosaurs, but in the sea. When I was about twelve, I dug out a huge ichthyosaur, a fish-lizard. Later I found a plesiosaur, with a neck so long you would hardly believe it. And once I found a flying reptile called a pterosaur.

Your dog is called Biscuit? My dog Tray comes fossil hunting with me, and he is very patient while I dig. Perhaps Biscuit could guard your ammonite.

Keep looking after storms, when new stones fall from the cliffs. But always stay far from the cliff edge, and watch the tide.

Your friend from the seashore,

Mary

P.S. Could you draw your ammonite for me and count its curls?



REAL HISTORY

The true story behind Mary's letter, for Oliver and a grown-up to read together.

1. Ammonites were sea creatures with curled shells. Their fossils are common on the beaches at Lyme Regis and Charmouth in Dorset.
2. Around 1811, Mary Anning, aged about 12, dug out most of an ichthyosaur skeleton. Her brother Joseph had found its skull.
3. In 1823 she found the first complete plesiosaur skeleton, and in 1828 the first pterosaur found in Britain.
4. Ichthyosaurs and plesiosaurs lived at the same time as dinosaurs, but they were sea reptiles, not dinosaurs.
5. Storytelling: Mary never wrote to children in the future, but she really did have a dog called Tray who came fossil hunting with her.

Write back to Mary!

Write here or on any paper you like. Then ask a grown-up to take a photo of it and upload it in your Letters from History account. Mary's next letter will answer you.

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